

An Unlikely Convert

Ben Shields · Emmaus Road Church, Bozeman, MT · October 4, 2026

Series: Acts

Acts 9:1-19 PRIMARY TEXT	40 min SERMON LENGTH	20 SCRIPTURE REFERENCES	52 SECTIONS WE MAPPED
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THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

Christ saves his people by sovereignly confronting them with his glory, convicting them of their guilt, consecrating them to himself, and commissioning them for the advance of his kingdom—a pattern revealed in Saul's conversion and true of every believer's salvation.

Summary

Ben Shields preaches Acts 9:1-19, the conversion of Saul of Tarsus, arguing that this most dramatic conversion in Scripture reveals the universal pattern by which Christ saves all his people. Saul—the church's most dangerous persecutor, a Pharisee consumed with hatred for Jesus—is confronted by the resurrected Christ on the Damascus road with blazing glory that strikes him blind. Shields traces four sovereign actions Christ takes in every conversion: confrontation (God interrupts the sinner's trajectory), conviction (exposing the sinner's guilt before divine righteousness), consecration (transforming the dead heart and setting the believer apart for Christ), and commission (sending the saved to witness). Though Saul's circumstances were extraordinary, every believer has experienced the same saving work. The sermon addresses Christians tempted to undervalue their testimonies for lack of drama, challenges believers to embrace their commission despite fear, and assures unbelievers that no one is beyond Christ's pursuing grace—if the chief persecutor could be saved, anyone can.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/EmmausRoadBozeman/sermons/acts-9-1-19-an-unlikely-convert-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The sermon's entire architecture rests on unpacking the mechanics of conversion through four sequential divine actions that apply salvation—confrontation, conviction, consecration, and commission.
- **Providence / Sovereignty** — Shields repeatedly emphasizes God's sovereign initiative in salvation, confronting sinners who have no desire for him and orchestrating even persecution (through Saul) to fulfill his redemptive purposes.
- **Christology** — The risen Christ is presented as the active agent in every conversion, personally confronting sinners with his glory and righteousness, speaking directly to Saul despite his hostility.
- **Ecclesiology** — The sermon treats commission as an essential component of salvation itself, arguing that every believer is consecrated not only from judgment but to kingdom work as Christ's witness.

Themes

Sovereignty of grace in conversion

No sinner beyond Christ's reach

Divine confrontation and conviction

Commission as intrinsic to salvation

Overcoming fear of man in witness

Pattern vs. circumstances in conversion

Editor notes

- The four-part conversion structure (confrontation, conviction, consecration, commission) is not just an outline but a hermeneutical grid Shields uses to make Saul's unique experience universally applicable—a strong interpretive move that unifies the entire sermon.
- The extended biographical exposition of Saul's credentials (units 12-18) builds dramatic tension by establishing exactly how unlikely a convert he was, making the Damascus road encounter land with greater force.

- Shields uses Ananias's fear as a pastoral on-ramp for contemporary application, acknowledging that Western Christians face social rather than physical persecution—a contextually aware move that validates real though lesser suffering.
- The closing use of 1 Timothy 1:12-17 is rhetorically powerful, letting Paul's own mature theological reflection on his conversion serve as both confirmation of the sermon's thesis and doxological benediction.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. God Doesn't Wait to Be Found: Why Christ Confronts Rather Than Invites

Many evangelicals treat salvation as if God sits passively waiting for seekers to stumble upon him—a cosmic lottery ticket. But Saul's conversion reveals the opposite: Christ actively confronts sinners on trajectories toward destruction, interrupting lives, forcing reckonings. This article explores why a confrontational Savior is both more biblical and more trustworthy than a passive one.

FROM: UNITS 21-24, WHERE SHIELDS CONTRASTS PASSIVE AND ACTIVE MODELS OF GOD'S SAVING WORK AND ARGUES THAT CHRIST'S CONFRONTATION OF SAUL REVEALS HIS UNIVERSAL PATTERN OF PURSUING THE LOST.

2. When Your Righteousness Isn't Righteous Enough: The Forensic Nature of Conviction

Saul thought he was blameless under the law—and by human standards, he was. But when confronted with Christ's perfect righteousness, his lifelong devotion crumbled. This article distinguishes between motivational 'conviction' (feeling bad) and forensic conviction (being declared guilty before God's standard), showing why even moral, religious people need the gospel.

FROM: UNITS 25-27, WHERE SHIELDS DEFINES CONVICTION AS FORENSIC GUILT AND APPLIES IT TO SAUL'S REALIZATION THAT HIS SELF-ASSESSED BLAMELESSNESS WAS INADEQUATE WHEN MEASURED AGAINST CHRIST.

3. Consecration Is Not Optional: Why Salvation Includes Assignment

Modern evangelicalism often separates justification from sanctification, treating mission as an add-on for the especially committed. But Saul's conversion challenges this: Christ consecrated him and immediately commissioned him before his sight returned. This article argues that being set apart to Christ inherently includes being set apart for kingdom work—there is no saved-but-uninvolved category.

FROM: UNITS 30-32, WHERE SHIELDS DEFINES CONSECRATION AS TRANSFORMATION THAT INCLUDES PURPOSEFUL ASSIGNMENT AND ARGUES BELIEVERS ARE SAVED NOT ONLY FROM JUDGMENT BUT TO WITNESS.

4. Your Testimony Is More Dramatic Than You Think

Many Christians undervalue their conversion stories because they lack external drama—no Damascus road light, no prison deliverance. But Shields argues the pattern matters more than the circumstances: if Christ confronted you, convicted you, transformed your dead heart, and commissioned you, your testimony contains the same sovereign miracle as Saul's. This article encourages believers to recognize and share the wonder of their own conversions.

FROM: UNITS 45-46, WHERE SHIELDS ADDRESSES CHRISTIANS WHO UNDERVALUE THEIR TESTIMONIES AND URGES THEM TO RECOGNIZE CHRIST'S SOVEREIGN INITIATIVE REGARDLESS OF EXTERNAL DRAMA.

5. Overcoming the Fear That Silences Your Witness: Lessons from Ananias

Ananias was commanded to minister to the man who came to arrest him—a terrifying assignment. His initial fear mirrors what many Christians feel when prompted to share the gospel: fear of mockery, social cost, relational damage. This article explores how Christ overcame Ananias's legitimate fear with a simple command grounded in sovereign purpose, and how the same pattern empowers contemporary witness.

FROM: UNITS 34-44, WHERE SHIELDS NARRATES ANANIAS'S FEAR AND CHRIST'S EMPOWERMENT, APPLYING IT TO CONTEMPORARY EVANGELISTIC CONTEXTS AND SOCIAL FEAR.

6. If Saul Can Be Saved, Anyone Can: The Gospel for Those Who Think They're Too Far Gone

The chief persecutor, breathing threats, orchestrating executions, consumed with hatred for Jesus—and Christ saved him. This article addresses the common objection that one might be beyond saving by pointing to Saul as proof that Christ's mercy is limitless, his grace boundless, and no sinner unreachable if God chooses to confront them.

FROM: UNITS 48-50, WHERE SHIELDS APPLIES THE SERMON EVANGELISTICALLY TO UNBELIEVERS WHO THINK THEY'RE BEYOND GRACE, USING SAUL AS PROOF OF CHRIST'S LIMITLESS PURSUING MERCY.

7. The Commission You Didn't Know You Received: Why Every Christian Is Sent

Many believers think of 'commission' as something that happened to the apostles or happens to missionaries—not to ordinary Christians. But Shields argues that commission is the fourth action in every conversion: Christ saves you and immediately sends you. This article explores how understanding commission as intrinsic to salvation (not optional discipleship) reshapes Christian identity and daily life.

FROM: UNITS 41-42 AND 47, WHERE SHIELDS DEFINES COMMISSION AS THE FOURTH SAVING ACTION AND ARGUES THAT BELIEVERS ARE CONSECRATED AND COMMISSIONED TO ADVANCE CHRIST'S KINGDOM THROUGH HOLINESS AND WITNESS.

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

What do the details in Acts 8:3 and 9:1 tell us about Saul's spiritual condition before his encounter with Christ? What was he actively seeking, and what was he completely unaware of?

- ↳ How does this reality challenge the idea that conversion begins with a person's spiritual search or desire to find God?

ACTS 8:3, 9:1

Walk us through what happened to Saul in Acts 9:3-5. What did Christ do in that moment, and what forced Saul to stop in his tracks?

- ↳ Why was this a confrontation rather than simply an invitation or opportunity?

ACTS 9:3-5

The sermon describes Christ's saving work in Saul's life as having four movements: confrontation, conviction, consecration, and commission. Looking at the pattern across Acts 9:1-19, how do you see each of these movements unfolding?

- ↳ Which of these four feels most foreign or challenging to how you've thought about your own conversion?

In 1 Timothy 1:12-17, Paul reflects back on his conversion years later. What does he say about the mercy he received, and how does that shape the way he understood what Christ did for him?

- ↳ How might Paul's gratitude in that passage be connected to the radical nature of his conversion—that Christ pursued and saved someone who was actively destroying the church?

1 TIMOTHY 1:12-17

Look at Ananias's response in Acts 9:13-14. What was Ananias afraid of, and what did Christ's command to him require? What does his obedience reveal about how the gospel uses ordinary believers in God's saving plan?

- ↳ When you think about sharing your faith this week, what fears tempt you in the same way Ananias was tempted, and how might remembering Christ's active pursuit of the lost change your willingness to speak?

ACTS 9:13-14

The sermon claims that every believer has experienced the same fourfold pattern Christ worked in Saul: confrontation, conviction, consecration, and commission. As you reflect on your own conversion and spiritual journey, where do you sense Christ is currently calling you to step into your commission—to be his witness and instrument in drawing others to saving knowledge of him?

Daily Readings

This week we trace the fourfold pattern of Christ's saving work revealed in Saul's conversion: confrontation, conviction, consecration, and commission—the same grace operative in every believer's salvation.

Monday [Acts 8:1-3](#)

Saul's frenzied persecution of the church—dragging believers to prison, consenting to Stephen's death, breathing threats against disciples—reveals a man consumed with religious zeal against Christ. Yet this very passage shows us that God's sovereign plan for salvation is not contingent on our seeking or worthiness; Christ actively pursues even the most hostile and lost. Our conversion, like Saul's, flows entirely from God's predetermined grace, not from our spiritual competence or willingness to be found.

Tuesday [Matthew 14:22-33](#)

When the disciples saw Jesus walking on the water, their first response was terror—a confrontation with transcendent power that shattered their assumptions and demanded recognition of his lordship. Like that moment, Saul's encounter with the risen Christ on the Damascus Road was an irruption of divine glory that stopped him mid-stride and forced absolute reckoning with who Jesus truly is. We too have experienced this confrontation, whether sudden or gradual—the moment Christ's presence became undeniable and we could no longer ignore his claim on our lives.

Wednesday [1 Timothy 1:12-17](#)

Paul himself reflects on his conversion with stunning clarity: he was a blasphemer, a persecutor, acting in ignorance and unbelief—yet he received mercy because Christ revealed the depth of his guilt and the sufficiency of grace. This passage shows us that conviction is not self-generated remorse but the forensic reality of standing guilty before God's perfect righteousness, combined with the Spirit's witness that only Christ's righteousness can cover that guilt. When we grasp, as Paul did, that our best religious works cannot save us and that we are hopelessly lost without Christ's substitutionary death, we experience the transformative power of true conviction.

Thursday [Philippians 3](#)

Paul's testimony in Philippians 3 shows the radical reversal wrought by consecration: everything he once counted as gain—his Pharisaic credentials, his zeal, his moral achievement—he now counts as loss for the surpassing worth of knowing Christ. Consecration means that Christ has claimed us wholly, covering our guilty hearts with his perfect righteousness and remaking us into vessels devoted entirely to his glory and purposes. We are not merely forgiven; we are permanently designated as belonging to Christ, our old identities crucified and new ones born in him.

Friday [Acts 1:8](#)

Jesus promised his disciples power to be his witnesses to the ends of the earth—a commission that Saul, transformed into Paul, would fulfill with extraordinary faithfulness despite suffering and rejection. Every one of us who has been confronted, convicted, and consecrated by Christ receives this same commission: we are sent as his witnesses, entrusted with the gospel message to carry to

those he is drawing. Our salvation is not a private transaction but a corporate calling—we have been saved not only for ourselves but to be Christ's instruments of grace in the salvation of others.

Memory Verse

*And falling to the ground, he heard a voice saying to him, 'Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?'
And he said, 'Who are you, Lord?' And he said, 'I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting.'
— Acts 9:4-5*

This verse captures Christ's sovereign, confrontational confrontation of Saul—the first and foundational action in salvation that the sermon identifies as universal to every believer's conversion. It crystallizes the sermon's central claim that Christ actively seeks and interrupts the sinner's trajectory, not passively waiting to be discovered.

Family Conversation

What Changed Saul's Mind?

Saul was so sure he was doing the right thing—hunting down Christians because he thought they were wrong. But then he met Jesus on the road, and everything changed. What's the difference between Saul deciding 'I guess I was wrong, I'll try harder now' and what actually happened to him when he saw Jesus' glory?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+

For parents: This prompt invites your family to explore the difference between *trying hard* to be good and having your heart completely transformed by encountering Jesus. Listen for whether kids see that Saul's change came from meeting Christ, not from deciding to be better.

For Couples

Confronted, Convicted, Consecrated, Commissioned

What struck you most about how Christ sovereignly confronted Saul—and what does it reveal about how Christ has confronted each of us in our own conversion?

How has Christ's consecration of us—his claiming us as his own and assigning us purpose—changed the way we see our marriage as a platform for gospel witness together?

What fear of man shows up most in our shared life, and how can we pray for courage to commission one another toward costly faithfulness in gospel witness?